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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Behavioral and Experimental Economics
Labor Economics, Public Economics, Development

EMPLOYMENT AND AFFILIATIONS

Finnish Centre of Excellence in Tax Systems Research (FIT) Postdoctoral Research Fellow	2024 -
Tampere University Postdoctoral Research Fellow	2024 -
Network on Welfare and Policy in Latin America and the Caribbean (WAPLAC) Affiliate Member	2023 -
Economics of Inequality and Poverty Analysis (EQUALITAS) Affiliate Member	2019 -

EDUCATION

Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona PhD, Applied Economics Advisor: Xavier Ramos	2019 - 2024
Norwegian School of Economics - FAIR Visiting student Host: Bertil Tungodden	Spring 2023
Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona M.Res., Applied Economics	2018 - 2019
Universidad de la República B.Sc., Economics	2009 - 2013

RESEARCH

[8] Brun, M. ‘The Complexity of Being Fair’.

We explore whether complexity shapes which fairness views people follow. We report findings from a lab-in-the-field experiment conducted with school students aged 10 to 15, a sample with significant cognitive variation and a uniform background. In the experiment, participants decide how to distribute earnings between workers who completed tasks under unequal opportunities. First, we examine whether differences in cognitive ability predict which fairness rules people follow. We find that higher-ability participants are more likely to follow meritocratic fairness views and prefer to compensate workers based on effort. The difference is driven by those who account for the unequal opportunities workers experience (a more complex decision rule), coinciding with a decline in egalitarian responses (a simpler decision rule). Second, we analyze the procedural aspects of the decisions. We show that higher-ability participants are better equipped to handle the counterfactual inferences needed to account for unequal opportunities. A between-subjects manipulation shows that providing this step closes the decision gap within meritocrats, whose decision rules differ only in the use of that step. This treatment effect is concentrated in lower-ability participants. These findings highlight the role of procedural choice in distributive decision-making and underscore cognition as an additional determinant of fairness pluralism.

[7] Brun, M., Mollerstrom, J. ‘Meritocratic Preferences, Cognitive Ability and Cognitive Load’.

We test the causal effect of cognitive load on redistributive decisions. Subjects participate in several decision rounds, in which they are assigned a digit to remember, make a redistributive decision, and are asked to recall the digit. We employ a 2x1 between-subject design. Subjects are either assigned to remember 6-digit number strings (e.g., 430890), or 1-digit number string (e.g., 4). Subjects act as third-party spectators and redistribute income between two other agents. Subjects face redistribution scenarios that differ in various characteristics, such as the source of the initial inequality and the merit of each agent. We explore whether our cognitive load intervention affects the decisions that subjects make, and how it impacts their decision-making process.

[6] Brun, M., Pogliano, A. ‘How Experiencing Unequal Circumstances Shapes Redistribution Decisions’.

Unequal opportunities are a defining feature of modern economies, yet individuals often disagree about whether and how inequalities deriving from unequal opportunities should be compensated. This paper studies whether experiencing unequal opportunities shapes redistributive behavior. We implement an experiment using a spectator design in which individuals first experience either an advantaged or disadvantaged version of an effort task and then evaluate redistribution between two workers who faced unequal task difficulty. By experimentally separating the experience of advantage or disadvantage from success or failure, we isolate how exposure to unequal opportunities affects beliefs and fairness judgments. We find that experiencing disadvantage leads spectators to attribute greater importance to circumstances in determining success and increases redistribution toward disadvantaged workers when redistribution is costless to the spectator. While redistribution decreases when it entails a personal cost, the gap between advantaged and disadvantaged spectators persists. These results provide causal evidence that lived experience of disadvantage reshapes beliefs about merit and fairness, with implications for how unequal opportunities are evaluated in redistributive decisions.

[5] Brun, M., Ramos, X. ‘Attitudes to Inequality and Preferences for Redistribution’.

We survey the literature on attitudes towards inequality and redistributive preferences. We focus on the effects of misperceptions, social preferences, and social identity. Recent contributions addressing these relationships have produced novel findings that are hardly covered in previous surveys. Before reviewing the empirical literature, we discuss how the theoretical literature has embedded in canonical models of social preferences the three issues we focus on in this review.

[4] Brun, M., Ramos, X. ‘Support for Redistribution and Cognitive Ability’.

Individual support for redistributive policies is frequently connected to earnings and the cognitive abilities that shape them. While support for redistribution is expected to decrease with income, the relationship with cognitive ability is more indirect and less clear. Higher-ability individuals tend to earn more, which predicts lower support for redistribution, but may also differ on other characteristics that go in opposite direction. To test whether the income channel prevails, we leverage data from two British cohort studies that allow linking reliable cognitive ability measurements in childhood to support for redistribution and income in adulthood. We find a clear moderation of the income effect on individuals with highest cognitive ability. We show that this pattern is explained by those with civic engagement (e.g., volunteering), pointing to social preferences as a key driver of support for redistribution among high-ability individuals.

[3] Brun, M., D’Ambrosio, C., Ferrer-i-Carbonell, A., Ramos, X. ‘Cognition and Health-distribution Preferences’.

We analyse individuals’ preferences vaccine-distribution schemes in the World, the EU, and their country of residence that emphasise circumstances rather than outcomes or effort. We link preferences to previously-measured cognition, and find that high-cognition individuals are 35% more likely to always support such schemes. These preferences are not driven by scheme convenience nor vaccine hesitancy, but appear to be caused by prosociality. We argue that this latter is linked to the perception of less equality of opportunity in society: despite having similar ideals about the role that effort and luck should play in life, high-cognition individuals perceive outcomes to be more determined by luck.

[2] Gomez-Ruiz, M., Brun, M., Marino, M., Ramos, X. ‘Role Models and Early Interest in STEM’.

We run an in-curricula field experiment in 53 schools in Uruguay. We investigate how the exposure to different role model’s characteristics impact early interest in STEM for 5th and 6th grade students. We manipulate the features of an 8-week long project on a scientist biography. Students work (i) either on a male or female biography, which (ii) includes or excludes growth mindset throughout the story. The intervention increases early interest in STEM, particularly in Engineering. The effectiveness varies depending on the gender match and the inclusion of a growth mindset component. We shed light on the underlying mechanisms by analyzing how gender stereotypes and norms, and growth mindset change when exposed to different role models.

[1] Brun, M., Calatayud, C., Elias, F., Martínez-Moya, J. ‘Earmarking as Commitment? Evidence from Catalonia’s Tourist Tax’.

We study the 2012 introduction of the Catalan tourist tax, whose revenues were legally earmarked for tourism-related expenditures and partially transferred to municipalities. We find that municipalities received transfers consistent with the statutory allocation rule and devoted about 70 percent of the additional resources to tourism promotion, while gradually reducing local property tax rates. The results suggest limited revenue fungibility and are consistent with the view that institutional design, together with the influence of organized interests and local democratic accountability, plays an important role in shaping the flypaper effect.

PUBLICATIONS

[5] Brodeur, A., Mikola, D., Cook, N., et al. (2026). ‘Reproducibility and robustness of economics and political science research’. **Nature** 652, 151-156.

[4] Brun, M., Gambetta, J.P., Varela, G. (2022). ‘Why do exports react less to real exchange rate depreciations than to appreciations? Evidence from Pakistan’. **Journal of Asian Economics** 81, 101496.

[3] Amarante, V., Brun, M., Rossel, C. (2020). ‘Poverty and inequality in Latin America’s research agenda: A bibliometric review’. **Development Policy Review** 38(4), 465-482.

[2] Amarante, V., Brun, M. (2018). ‘Cash transfers in Latin America: Effects on poverty and redistribution’. **Economía** 19(1), 1-31.

[1] Brun, M., Rius, A. (2016). ‘La Lógica de los Auges de Inversión’. **Revista de Economía** 23(2), 45-99.

SEMINARS, CONFERENCES AND PRESENTATIONS

- 2026:** *EALE Conference 2026 (UB); 2026 ESA European Meeting (UPF); Department of Economics (Girona, invited).*
- 2025:** Meritocracy and Fairness: Economic Perspectives (SSE); 41st Summer Seminar of Finnish Economists 2025 (Jyväskylä); 2025 ESA European Meeting (Masaryk); 4th Workshop on Field Experiments in Economics and Business (TUM Munich); Helsinki Graduate School of Economics (HGSE, invited); 17th Nordic Conference in Behavioral and Experimental Economics (Stavanger); Turku School of Economics (Turku, invited); Finnish Centre of Excellence in Tax System Research (Tampere); 2025 FIT Seminar (Tampere); FAIR (NHH, invited).
- 2024:** 17th Winter School on Inequality and Social Welfare Theory (Verona); Vienna Workshop on Social Choice and Fairness (Wein); 16th Maastricht Behavioral and Experimental Economics Symposium (Maastricht); 25th IZA Summer School in Labor Economics (IZA); 1st Summer School in Experimental and Behavioral Economics (EER); 2024 ESA European Meeting (Hanken); Finnish Centre of Excellence in Tax System Research (Tampere); 2024 FIT Seminar (Tampere).
- 2023:** FAIR (NHH); XI Doctoral Workshop (UAB); 10th ECINEQ Meeting (Aix-Marseille); Applied Lunch (UAB).
- 2022:** Department of Economics (UdelaR, invited); X Doctoral Workshop (UAB); 47th SAE Symposium (Valencia).
- 2021:** 9th ECINEQ Meeting (LSE); 20th Journées Louis-André Gérard-Varet (Aix-Marseille); 25th Spring Meeting of Young Economists (Bologna); IX Doctoral Workshop (UAB); Applied Lunch (UAB); 14th RGS Doctoral Conference in Economics (RGS Econ); Recent advances in poverty and inequality research (LISER).

2020: XI Uruguayan Meeting (NIP); XXXV Annual Economic Workshop (Uruguayan Central Bank); VIII Doctoral Workshop (UAB); 8th Workshop on Industrial and Public Economics (Rovira i Virgili).
2019: VIII Annual Meeting (SEU); Institute of Economics (UdelaR).
PrePhD: VI Academic Workshop (UdelaR); WINIR 2016 Conference (WINIR); XXXI Annual Economic Workshop (Uruguayan Central Bank); Institute of Economics (UdelaR).

TEACHING

Micro
Behavioral Economics (graduate). Lecturer (TUNI) Spring 2025, *Spring 2027*

Econometrics
Econometrics 1 (graduate). Teaching Assistant (UAB) Fall 2023

Macro
Corporate Finance (graduate). Lecturer (TUNI) Spring 2026
International Economics. Lecturer (UAB) Fall 2022, Spring 2024
Public Economics. Teaching Assistant (UAB) Spring 2021
Advanced Macroeconomics. Lecturer (UdelaR) Spring 2016, Spring 2017, Spring 2018

Maths
Mathematical Economics. Teaching Assistant (UdelaR) Fall 2016, Fall 2017
Algebra 1. Teaching Assistant (UdelaR) Fall 2014
Calculus 1. Teaching Assistant (UdelaR) Spring 2014

Introductory
Introduction to Economics. Lecturer (UAB) Fall 2021
Economic Theory. Lecturer (UAB) Spring 2021
Descriptive Economics. Teaching Assistant (UdelaR) Fall 2015

GRANTS, HONORS AND AWARDS

2023: R&D+i project PID2022-137352NB-C41 (~€37,500). Spanish Ministry of Science and Innovation.
2023: Erasmus+ KA131 mobility programme for outgoing PhD students (~€1,000). European Commission.
2020: Grant for the Recruitment of New Research Staff (~€70,000). Generalitat de Catalunya.
2019: 1st place (out of 34 students) in M.Res. in Applied Economics. Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona.
2018: Latin American Excellence Scholarship for M.Sc. in Economics (~£17,500, *declined*). University of Leeds.
2013: 1st place (out of 127 students) in B.Sc. in Economics. Universidad de la República.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

2026-27: Co-organizer of the 17th Nordic Conference in Behavioral and Experimental Economics.
2023-24: Student representative in the Executive Board of the UAB Applied Economics Department.
2023-24: Student representative in the Council of the UAB Applied Economics Department.
2022-23: Co-organizer of the econisers PhD student group.
2021-23: Co-founder and co-organizer of the REGROUPED reading group.
Referee: Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization; Social Choice & Welfare; Review of Income & Wealth; Journal of Asian Economics; Spring Meeting of Young Economists.

PREVIOUS PROFESSIONAL APPOINTMENTS

Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona 2020 - 2024
Research Fellow

World Bank 2019 - 2023
External Collaborator

Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean 2014 - 2018; 2021 - 2022
Consultant

International Labour Office 2017
Consultant

Universidad de la República 2013 - 2018
Adjunct Professor

Deloitte S.C. 2011 - 2013
Assistant in the Economics and Financial Advisory area

LANGUAGES AND SKILLS

Languages: English (fluent), Spanish (native), Catalan (intermediate), Portuguese (basic), Finnish (alkeet).
Coding: Python, R, Stata, oTree, Git, HTML/CSS, JavaScript, L^AT_EX

OTHERS

Family Leaves: December 2025.